ROYAL NAVY BATTLES

AT THE END of the War of the Spanish Succession in 1713 Britain was indisputably Europe's dominant naval power. In a brief war with Spain from 1718 to 1720, it crushed the Spanish navy almost effortlessly. British merchants urged their government to use sea power aggressively to advance the nation's trade. The severing of the ear of Captain Robert Jenkins, master of the trading brig *Rebecca*, by Spanish coast guards in the Caribbean in 1731 provided ammunition for those arguing for action against Spain's empire in the Americas. The War of Jenkins' Ear, launched by Britain on a tide of jingoistic enthusiasm in 1739, began well with the capture of Porto Bello, but soon ran into disaster in the failed expedition against Cartagena de Indias. This ignominious defeat severely dented British prestige. The war of the Austrian Succession (1740–48) brought Britain once more into conflict with its old enemy France, as well as with Spain. The French navy was in no condition to challenge British supremacy, and the British found themselves fighting, with varying degrees of competence, engagements in which they held a clear superiority.

WAR OF THE QUADRUPLE ALLIANCE

CAPE PASSARO



Date August 11, 1718
Forces British: 21 ships of the line; Spanish: 18 ships of the line
Losses British: none; Spanish: 11 ships of the line captured or burned

Location Cape Passaro, southeast Sicily

In 1718 Britain sent a fleet to the Mediterranean under Admiral Sir George Byng to oppose Spanish ambitions in Sicily. Although Britain and Spain were not officially at war, Byng pursued a Spanish squadron under Vice Admiral Don Antonio Castaneta down the east coast of Sicily. At daybreak on August 11 battle was joined. Byng's 90-gun *Barfleur* and the other largest British ships overcame one Spanish division, including Castaneta's flagship *Real San Felipe*, while Captain George Walton led the chase of another, laconically reporting: "We have taken or destroyed all the Spanish ships which were upon this coast the number as per margin."

The British Mediterranean squadron
British ships of the line under Admiral Byng stop at Naples en route to Sicily. They engaged the Spanish near Cape Passaro, south of Messina.



WAR OF JENKINS' EAR

PORTO BELLO



Date November 21–22, 1739
Forces British: 6 ships of the line
Losses none

Location Porto Bello, Panama

The desire of British merchants wanting access to the markets of the Spanish Empire in the Americas reached fever pitch in 1738 when Captain Jenkins exhibited his ear, severed by Spanish coast guards, to the House of Commons. Naval officer and Member of Parliament Edward Vernon boasted that he could take Porto Bello, a Caribbean port used for the export of silver, "with six ships only." Succumbing to the pressure for war, in 1739 the British government made Vernon a vice admiral with orders to do just that. Vernon appeared off Porto Bello on November 20 with seven ships, one of which he sent away so he could fulfil his promise. The following day, with his flag on board the 64-gun *Hampton Court*, he led his ships in line into Porto Bello. The assortment of coast-guard vessels and warships present could offer no resistance to the British squadron, but the fort of San Felipe, with some 100 guns manned by 300 soldiers, had to be overcome. A failing wind for a time left *Hampton Court* immobilized and alone under the fort's guns, although her broadsides were easily a match for the shore batteries. When the other ships came up the balance of firepower swung heavily against the fort, which surrendered after the landing of marines. Thomas Arne composed "Rule Britannia" for the celebrations and areas of London, Dublin, and Edinburgh were named Portobello.

WAR OF JENKINS' EAR

CARTAGENA



Date March 14–May 20, 1741
Forces British: 29 ships of the line, c.150 other vessels; Spanish: 6 ships of the line
Losses British: 50 ships of all kinds; Spanish: 6 ships of the line

Location Cartagena de Indias, Colombia

The success at Porto Bello in 1739 inspired the British to prey further upon Spain's colonial possessions. A massive force, requiring a quarter of the entire strength of the Royal Navy, was sent to the Caribbean the following year. The death of the expedition's overall commander, Lord Cathcart, en route left the naval force under Vice Admiral Edward Vernon, victor of Porto Bello, and the troops under Major-General Thomas Wentworth, with no one to arbitrate if they disagreed.



Victory medal
The Vernon medal was struck by the British to celebrate the taking of Cartagena—which in fact never happened.

Britain's target was Cartagena de Indias, the major port in Spanish-ruled New Grenada. Leading its defense was Admiral Bas de Lezo, one of Spain's most gallant naval commanders, who had lost a leg, an arm, and an eye in a distinguished fighting career. He had only six ships of the line to face the British armada, but had no intention of giving in. The British arrived off the city in mid-March and settled down to a bombardment of its walls. The entrance to the harbor was defended by shore batteries and the guns of de Lezo's six ships anchored inside. On April 15, the British attempted a sea and land assault on these defenses. After a sharp fight de Lezo scuttled his ships to keep them out of British hands and fell back on the port's inner fort. As time passed and tempers frayed, cooperation between Vernon and Wentworth broke down. Land assaults proved to be costly failures, while Vernon's ships bombarding the walls came under damaging fire from shore guns. Caribbean epidemic diseases raged, decimating naval crews and troops. After 67 fruitless days the British sailed away on May 20, burning some of their ships because they had no crews left to man them. De Lezo did not enjoy his triumph for long, dying of a wound sustained in the siege. The British government was embarrassed by this ignominious defeat because the operation had been prematurely hailed as a triumph and victory medals struck.

Spanish fortifications
The fort of Cartagena, where the British attack of 1741 was repulsed. As a result, Spain retained control of its highly lucrative colony.

